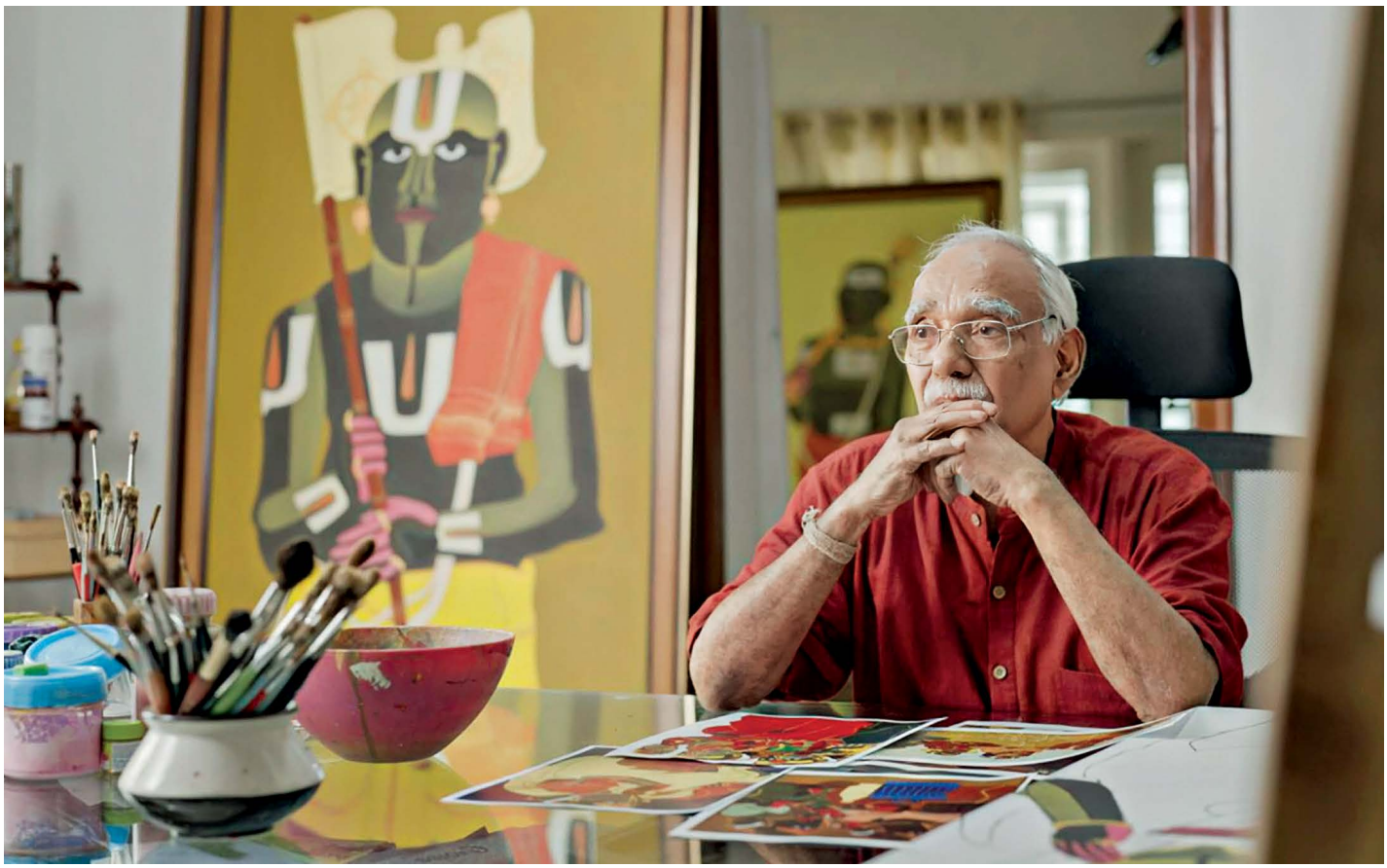


Q+A

COUNTRY **CANVASES**

Delhi's Art Alive Gallery is hosting a solo show of 82-year-old artist ***Thota Vaikuntam****'s work*—Redefining the Cultural Gaze—*till Nov. 20. A documentary about his life has also been released*

Q. Tell us about your early life in rural Telangana and how those experiences inform your practice

When I was a child, I would observe that almost every community living in the village, and in neighbouring ones, had their own art forms, their own styles. I was also very taken with local theatre groups, the way they told stories of our heroes like Hanuman or Bheema or Krishna. I wanted to draw these incredible characters and my journey in art started that way.

Q. Your drawings of Krishna emphasise his identity as a villager. How did you arrive at this style?

So, if you look at my paintings, Krishna or Krishna-like figures with flutes on their lips are freely present among the villagers, mixing among regular folk. And that's the sense I wanted to capture, of God as a constant, everyday presence in the lives of these people. For them, God is not a remote concept or something abstract.

Q. Would you say your basic method has remained unchanged all these years?

I still begin my work with charcoal and then add the colours layer by layer. So, the basic method hasn't changed. But yes, my thoughts about the work, how I planned large-scale paintings in particular changed because of what I could see my teachers (at the College of Fine Arts and Architecture, Hyderabad) or my colleagues doing.

Q. At this stage in your career, what are the themes and ideas that get you excited?

I remain committed to drawing ordinary people from Telangana. The difference is that now I am focusing more on paintings that depict large groups, instead of sketches of individuals. Recently, a lot of paintings I did involved music or musical instruments. Music adds a touch of the dramatic to these works and plus, it plays such a big role in the lives of rural folk.

–with Aditya Mani Jha